May 26, 1961

IBM CONFIDENTIAL

Memorandum to: W. B. McWhirter

Subject: STRETCH Evaluation; Dr. Kolsky's Report

I have read Dr. Kolsky's report with great interest and feel that it is an excellent document and certainly will treat it in my summary of Dr. Meagher's and Mr. Adams' work.

I think it is natural that Dr. Kolsky would have some trepidations in regard to the reports that Adams or Meagher would submit. It is obvious that it is not an easy task for outsiders to uncover the problems concerned with STRETCH and the reasons for these problems, and having participated in some of the discussions that Dr. Kolsky had with Mr. Adams, it is a natural conclusion that the reports could be expected to be shallow and incriminatory in nature.

I have reviewed Dr. Meagher's report and the draft of Mr. Adams' report and in my opinion they have done an excellent job in evaluating the STRETCH machine and the evolution of its design during the course of its development. This investigation of the development of STRETCH has resulted in their specifying "lessons to be learned" as opposed to the typical "witch hunt" our people sometimes associate with consultant work.

The lessons to be learned are by and large the same ones Dr. Kolsky treats in his report of May 8. For example, both Dr. Meagher and Mr. Adams feel the "3 and 1 concept" had a lasting and definite detrimental effect on the STRETCH program. Both observe that our organizational changes within the Company had a detrimental effect on the STRETCH program as well. These and many other observations were made by both consultants and Dr. Kolsky.

Dr. Kolsky's paper is an important and good one and amplifies the independent work of Dr. Meagher and Mr. Adams. Dr. Kolsky has a unique position to view STRETCH having been a member of the original Los Alamos evaluation group and then a member of the original IBM planning staff.

His intimacy with the entire STRETCH development program provides him with a much better insight to the financial and political difficulties that STRETCH encountered. During the course of Dr. Meagher's and Mr. Adams' investigation, I did not think it was possible or proper to have them review the entire financial history of STRETCH; hence, this is an area not treated in their reports.

With your permission, I am forwarding a copy of the STRETCH evaluation made by Dr. Meagher for Mr. Kolsky's review. By carbon copy of this letter I am asking him (Dr. Kolsky) to provide me with his comments on this evaluation and his concurrence that Dr. Meagher's report lists the same major problems that Dr. Kolsky has. I will propose to ask him to do the same with Mr. Adams' report when it becomes available. After this review, I will plan to meet with Dr. Kolsky to discuss the subject in more detail.

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cc: C. R. DeCarlo
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